TRUMP SAW INDIA AS A COUNTRY THAT WAS BIG ENOUGH TO MAKE A DIFFERENCE BUT NOT LARGE ENOUGH TO CAUSE PROBLEMS AND PUSHED HARD TO GET INDIA TO BUY US OIL AND ARMAMENTS

Secretary of State Marco Rubio in his first day in office by convening a Quad meeting. Later, Modi in his meeting with Trump said he looked forward to hosting the US president in New Delhi when the Quad leaders' summit would be held in September 2025.

Another plus for India was the US Supreme Court clearing the extradition of Tahawwur Hussain Rana, a Pakistan-origin businessman and physician who was arrested in Chicago in 2009 for his role in abetting the horrific 26/11 Mumbai attacks the previous year. India had waged a long battle for his extradition. In his summit with Modi, Trump promised to have Rana extradited to India at the earliest. Pakistan gnashed its teeth when the two leaders went on to reaffirm their commitment to eliminate the global scourge of terrorism, even telling Islamabad to stop fostering terrorist activities on its soil. That was a win for India too.

TARIFFS AND A NEW DEAL

Meanwhile, given Trump's obsession with trade tariffs, the Modi government decided to partially address his demands. In the 2025 Union budget and later, many of the tariffs for US exports to India that Trump wanted lowered in his first term were reduced. These included duties on Bourbon whisky, high-end motorcycles, medical devices and agricultural products like alfalfa hay and dry fruits. The idea was

P-8I maritime patrol aircraft, adding to a fleet of 12.

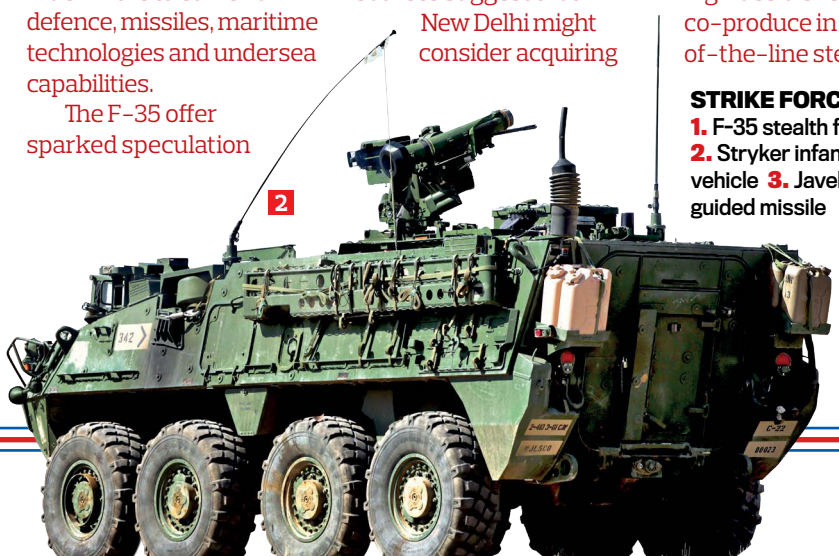
India has bought over $20 billion (Rs 1.73 lakh crore) worth of American defence materiel since 2008, making the US its third-largest arms supplier. India has historically relied on Russian and European defence equipment, though it has increasingly diversified its sources, including through substantial American equipment. The India-US joint statement hinted at much more to come—air defence, missiles, maritime technologies and undersea capabilities.

The F-35 offer sparked speculation because India is pursuing its own fifth-generation stealth fighter programme, the Advanced Medium Combat Aircraft (AMCA), but it remains years away from operational readiness. However, foreign secretary Vikram Misri was quick to clarify: "I don't think with regard to the acquisition of an advanced aviation platform by India ...that process has started as yet."

Though there are no immediate plans for F-35s, sources suggest that New Delhi might consider acquiring two squadrons of F-35s as a 'stopgap measure'. However, the F-35 doesn't just cost a bomb, its maintenance costs are also substantial; nor is it without operational black spots. Moreover, American restrictions on technology transfer could limit India's ability to customise the aircraft to its specific needs.

There are also those who think that Trump's offer of F-35 is part of his 'disruptive diplomacy' to prevent India from accepting Russia's recent offer to co-produce in India its top-of-the-line stealth fighter, the impressive Su-57E, alongside assistance in the development of the Indian fifth generation fighter programme. Others say America's offer could be a strategic counter to China's rapidly increasing stealth fighter force and thus beneficial to India. Just two months ago, Beijing unveiled its sixth-generation stealth fighter prototype, the J-36. Meanwhile, Pakistan is also accelerating the induction of 40 J-35 stealth fighters from China.

Former IAF chief Vivek Ram Chaudhari has the final word. "What the fifth generation fighters can bring to us is more important...which aircraft is a secondary matter. We want any new technologies to encourage our self-reliance a little more and give a further boost to our AMCA programme," he says. ■





STRIKE FORCE
1. F-35 stealth fighter jet
2. Stryker infantry combat vehicle **3.** Javelin anti-tank guided missile

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